

It's all well and good to go out and buy the best DVD-writer, but what use is it if you're not using the most powerful application to power them? We've tested eight of the best disc burning software for both Windows as well as Linux

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DVD and CD writing software go hand-in-hand with DVD-Writers, which we've also tested this month. If you're planning on getting a DVD-Writer, you'll need software to complement it. Windows XP does come with a CD-Writing wizard, but it cannot burn to DVD (it can't create a VCD or bootable CD either, for that matter).

You're probably aware of Nero Burning ROM—it's packaged with most CD/DVD-Writers here in India. And you're probably not aware of the alternatives. There are several, and here, we present a comparison of six burning software packages—including the well-known Nero, of course. All these are available easily off the Internet.

Some time ago, CD burning software were meant solely for the purpose of recording CDs, but these days, they're coming bundled with additional software such as media players, video encoders, audio rippers, image creators, and more. They also support many data formats (DVD±R/RW, DVD-RAM, dual-layer, ISO, UDF, HFS, etc.) and hardware compatibility is not an issue any more. A burning software can now replace several other software; for instance, you don't need image creators such as WinISO or Alcohol—most CD-Writing software now have a bundled application for the same purpose.

In this test, we've also featured two Linux-based burning software. Open source's baby K3b and NeroLinux lock heads in the Linux segment. And for Windows XP, we have Disc Master 2, Easy Media Creator 8, Nero 7 Premium, NTI CD&DVD Maker, RecordNow! Deluxe, and CyberLink's Power2Go.

BURNING SOFTWARE FOR WINDOWS XP

Ahead Nero 7 Premium

Bid adieu to Nero 6, and make way for the new Nero 7 Premium! The new version has "feature-rich"

written all over it. For example, it comes with Nero Home, a media manager to manage your entire multimedia collection.

Features

Nero has all the features you can think of! This is a fully loaded software—Burning ROM 7, WaveEditor3, Vision 4, Recode, ShowTime 2, PhotoSnap, CoverDesigner 2 and more figure on the list of features.

There are two aspects to any burning software—its core functionality and the bundled features. We can assure you that Nero doesn't lack in either department. Features such as multi-session, overburning, disc image recording, dual-layer DVD support, and support for burning other media formats such as VCD and video DVD—they're all there. Well, Nero can't write WMA CDs, which is hardly important since most players, at least in India, are mostly designed to play back MP3 discs. But still, Easy Media Creator 8 supports all three types—WAV, MP3 and WMA.



Nero StartSmart is a wizard by Nero that displays all the utilities and burn projects at once

Packages similar to Nero WaveEditor 3 and SoundTrax 2 for audio editing, Nero PhotoSnap for picture editing, and Nero ShowTime are available in other burning software as well. But with Vision 4, Nero has inherently enhanced the capability to handle recording of video files in different formats. You no longer need separate software—it's all bundled in Nero 7 Premium.

Nero also allows video capture

from a device such as DV cam to DVD video format and then burning of the file to DVD media with Burning ROM. You can also create images of a CD or DVD, and also mount them on Nero Image Drive, a virtual CD/DVD drive.

Ease Of Use

Installation is easy, and if you don't want to install certain components, you can choose the custom install option. Nero 7's interface is very similar to that of its prior versions—there are only a few minor changes.

The Start Smart Wizard introduces a newbie to the world of disc recording. There's no way you can go wrong if you use the Wizard!

In Nero, all options are always listed, and you're guided at every stage; right-clicking on certain buttons and icons in the main interface displays an explanation. If you need documentation, though, you'll have to visit www.nero.com/nero7/eng/FAQs_Manuals_Helpfiles.html.

Performance

Nero has always been resource-hungry. Many people restrain themselves from doing multiple tasks on their machines while Nero is burning a disc. This may, in fact, be good practice if you don't have top-of-the-line hardware. If you have, say, 128 MB of RAM, you could just end up with a cyclic redundancy error if you do many other things while Nero is doing its job.

When you run Nero, the memory usage shoots up by a hundred megabytes or more; refer to the table for details. This is one area where Nero must improve—there happen to be software in this test that use a minimum of resources.

Site:

www.nero.com/nero7/eng/index.html

CyberLink Power2Go

CyberLink's Power2Go supports all types of media formats. On the regular features front, it has everything to give Nero and CyberLink tough competition.